

FIRST EDITION



The
ZERO
Agenda

BY
BERNARD
ALAIN

The poems in this edition represent an early selection from The Zero Agenda, an ongoing series.

Additional poems and updated editions will be released periodically.

Thank you for reading.

The Zero Agenda

Poems by Bernard Alain

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Ottawa, Ontario, Canada.

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Framing Eden

In May toward the end.

8:00 a.m. on a Sunday / the sill

Today, there is no departure.

Only tendrils reaching into the morning sun.

Both the cacti and the birds of paradise

died an early death this year—

The dracaena of course surviving neglect.

Some stubborn sense of purpose.

The gaps between the slats

let in only the most opulent of blue-eyes—

viridity

a tenacious insider.

Pulling Teeth

Later in March sometime.
8:06 a.m. on a Monday / rot.

Belvedere Avenue has two exits:
at the top & to the left—
for golfers and grandchildren,
at the bottom & to the right—
for everything else.

Today—the dentist.
I turn right.

The Ottawa River slowly reconnects
between the trees.

They moved the fishing shack with a huge
Canadian flag painted on its side—off thin ice,
onto some soggy extension.
The traffic up ahead reduced to one lane.

My foot never completely off the brake.
The pears from Portugal—fermenting
in the elastic cargo net as the strait fills up.

Finally,
a construction worker
wearing a yellow safety vest
flips the paddle from stop to slow.
I pass—lock eyes.
Open—

for the moment.

Total Compliance

In May sometime.

6:05 a.m. on a Tuesday / drips & drops

Belvedere Avenue has only one exit,
at the bottom & to the right—

No straddling the back nine.

No fancy pastry.

Just coconut oil and cinnamon drops—

I pass the community water supply pumps—
double back.

The taps are down to a trickle in Rockland again.

A two cup day maybe—
one for the plants,
one for a strong coffee.

I arrive at the top of the hill.
A bit of sweat.

sustainable.

The Third Man Factor

Later in May sometime.

5:30 a.m. on a Tuesday / dropping kPa

I turn right with a quick left in mind.

My strides are brisk.

I could break into a jog.

Leap ahead.

DNA Automotive—

the Jehovah's Witness complex—

disappear behind me.

The kid on the hi-tech scooter overtakes the jogger.

The jogger and the dog overtake me.

Plugged ears—

Shortened breath—

The barometer—

Kilimanjaro comes to mind.

—that and the little man.

The Circle Game

Later in April sometime.

6:34 a.m. Monday / wet

Today, I only make it as far as the curb on
Belvedere Avenue.

A patch of dandelions forming on the easement.

No evidence of the blue-eyes.

A small gang of dogs out sniffing 'o'.

The shih poos and the russells
never seem to settle.

A Following

In April sometime.

7:30 a.m. on a Saturday / howler

I chase the brouhaha.

It was the love mud.

The extra coat—from the car wash puddle
at the bottom of the street.

possibly the same bad boys
that flattened the rose bush.

Front Yard Critic

Early in June sometime.

10:00 a.m. on a Saturday / doggie style

Off to get some groceries.

Mike across the way is working on his truck.

The shih poo is off the leash again.

He runs across three front lawns.

Plows through the hyacinths.

Arrives at my toes

with his hair done up in a pink bow

and a flip-flop in his mouth.

Says nothing.

The Outcropping

Later in May sometime.

7:41 a.m. on a Tuesday / schizo

Belvedere Avenue has one exit—
at the bottom & to the right.

I deviate.

A small unmarked park just after
Laurier Avenue on Caron.

The tall grass between
the construction aggregate—almost
a herbarium /
the misfits—

A nameless rider
wearing Prada shades passes by
on a scooter.

Eastbound & westbound—
bumper to bumper.

Daytime lights still on.

Parallel Park

In April sometime.

10:15 a.m. on a Friday / the shoulder

Today I turn right—
towards St. Faustina's.

I am not a goer.

I am here for the extra left turn.

The parking lot is already full—

the extra spots just off the main drag.

Late as usual.

Ten Hail Marys

Early in June sometime.

11:05 a.m. on a Tuesday / distillate

I travel past the last Moodie turn-off sign.

Turn on Wheeler—

Uphill into unimpeded blue.

The saloon leagues casually conspire
among the barn-gray mansards—like pirate ships
on a sea of green.

I pull into the laneway.

The husky is always barking.

Todd of course, would suck the bottle dry.

What didn't sing like Moon Harbor—stored
in mason jars behind the cellar door.

Low-Dose Alternatives

Later in May sometime.

9:21 a.m. on a Wednesday / strictly speaking

Off to the pharmacy.

I turn left on Laurier.

The radio bleats an aspirin endorsement.

More news on the oil tankers and the strait.

we are what we eat.

I pass the tailors on the left.

Pass by McDonald's.

I turn off the Hormuz updates—
one per day.

max.

The Many Ways to Die

In May toward the end.

6:00 a.m. on a Sunday / Koi Pla, and the live red ants

Today, there is departure but only essence.

We imagine some other way of being.

Where what consumes us has legs and eyes,
but mostly feels—never thinks.

It's the lemon juice that would make me squint.

Though having never really known hunger.

They would surely die quietly when
swallowed—like leaves falling from a tree.

So many poisons—

Life too short to worry about what
might eat you up from the inside out.

Nothing like the tree in the forest,
and how it goes down.

Nevermind the flukes.

On Taming the Shrew

Later in April sometime.

10:16 a.m. on a Thursday / as if

I pass a staggered array
of ice shacks and idle punts—
pulled to the river's edge.

Bob in the blue pickup ahead of me—
en route to the big city.
"So much for Kentucky," he says.

The ripples,
an occasional white crest,
maybe an eyebrow lifting up
among the wavelets—

how undisturbed the riverscape.

The No Free Lunch Policy

In April sometime.

10:45 a.m. on a Saturday / going numb

I turn right, the dentist.

The hygienist goes on about her nieces. Prying
at the sensitive areas from time to time—asking
if I feel anything.

The intake clerk fills out the balance
of my invoice—smiles.
I swipe.

the anesthesia already wearing off.

Sweet Surrender

Much later in December sometime.
10:05 a.m. on a Saturday / mall diastolic

I turn right—to St. Laurent Mall,
in search of a chocolatier—the last ditch for
schmoozers and lollygaggers.

Chocolate, maple taffy
and sea salt.
High-end turtles maybe.
The Purdy sales clerk already leaning in.

A Toys "R" Us bag passes by, followed by a
small cadre of whining toddlers.

I eat it.

Full Circle

The middle of July sometime.
7:30 a.m. on a Monday / warping

Today I test my e-bike,
turn left, follow the course on
Tucker Road at the end of David Street—
chase the back nine.

In the rearview: DriFits, Polos.
Absorber shocks.

I re-enter Belvedere Avenue,
dial up to third.

Mike from across the street—outside
putting the big knobbies on his 4x4.

He refers to me as the old guy.
The shih poos have no opinion.

The BBQ Pit

In May toward the end.

8:00 a.m. on a Saturday / out back

Today, there is no departure
just submission—almost Hallmark.

The hyacinths so thick they seem almost
self-extinguishing.

And I am thankful for the humor, the introspection,
the lack of rhyme.

The hallelujahs I could do without.

The creaking and moaning of a backyard
apparatus.

As before
the rest hanging in the cedars, a row out back
that unrelents.

Where teacups and other fine breeds
lift legs purely out of habit.

I retreat from a grille that slowly burns
this Canadian kabob.
Hoping the CO won't attract more microscopic drills
and other airborne things.

I slap my wrist.
Keep the zapper on.

The ZERO Agenda

The Zero Agenda gathers a series of observational poems set largely in and around Ottawa, Canada. Part travelogue, part notebook, part ongoing investigation, these poems find meaning not in grand events but in the overlooked details of everyday life: a crowded church parking lot, a pharmacy run, a neighbor's dog, a patch of wildflowers, a turn taken for no particular reason.

Written in a voice that is by turns wry, reflective, and quietly amused, the collection follows a speaker who treats the smallest incidents as worthy of attention. The clues are often tiny, the stakes modest, yet the impulse to observe remains constant. What emerges is a portrait of place, habit, aging, curiosity, and the peculiar dramas hidden within ordinary days.

Bernard Alain is a Canadian poet whose work explores memory, landscape, family, and the overlooked corners of everyday experience. He lives in Ottawa, where many of the roads, rivers, parking lots, and side streets that populate these poems continue to provide material for further investigation.

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